

The Crimson Troupe

The bell chimed once more as the sliding glass doors opened themselves up for another soon to be patron of the small convenience store. The yellow sky broke its way through the trees overhead, their leaves now shades of red and orange, and illuminated the store's windows. Ghosts hanging from the ceiling, fake skeletons, all tied up in thick cobwebs and all staring out at the kids in the parking lot who lacked the money, or ability to steal, they needed if they wanted a snack. Timmy sat on the sidewalk with his back up against the store wall, sipping from a can of soda. Bucky stepped out of the store holding a plastic bag and sat down next to his friend. He pulled out a bag of chips and tore it open. Timmy reached over and pulled out a chip before Bucky could yank the bag away. The two sat there and watched as people continued to walk in and out of the store.

"Do you have your costume yet?" Timmy asked Bucky as he took a bite of his stolen chip.

"Nah, my parents have been too busy to take me anywhere. And considering that it's already the Monday before Halloween, I might just go as a pirate again," Bucky answered and he shoved a handful of chips into his mouth. "What about you?" he asked in a voice muffled by the food in his mouth.

"I think I'm going as a cat this year," Timmy said as he took another sip of his drink. He could see Bucky eyeing him down through his peripheral vision. "It's not like I chose the costume, my parents want me to go as one cause they said it would be cute," Timmy said in a guilty voice.

"Why are your parents deciding what you're gonna be for Halloween?" Bucky asked.

"I just didn't feel like arguing with them ok?" Timmy said in an effort to end the conversation. Bucky shrugged and went back to wolfing down chips.

A cool wind blew past and Bucky shivered, zipping up his jacket. His face suddenly lit up as he remembered something.

"Have you seen that freak show setting up in town, The Crimson Troupe? I'm pretty sure they're like a traveling circus or something. They open the night before Halloween if you wanna go," Bucky said with excitement as Timmy looked at him sorrowfully.

"Yea, I've seen it. I would go but it'll be a school night, I doubt my parents would let me," he said. Bucky groaned and turned to face Timmy.

"They're a traveling freak show whose first performance is at midnight, you think anyone's parents are *letting* them go?" Bucky said as if every kid in the town knew this already. Timmy ran his finger around the rim of his soda can and sighed.

"Well look who it is!" a harsh voice ripped through the calm air like a crack of thunder and Timmy nearly jumped out of his skin. The pair looked over to see a familiar trio of teenagers walking towards them, led by a skinny kid with a black shirt and scar across his nose, James. The two stood up in an attempt to make themselves appear more threatening, they were still a couple

inches shorter than the teens though. Timmy noticed Bucky pull something out of his plastic bag and put it behind his back, subtly shaking it up.

“Looks like these two got lost,” James barked out, a toothy grin plastered on his face. “Hey knuckleheads, daycare’s back that way,” he said while pointing behind him. They all laughed at James’s joke and Timmy looked over at Bucky, hoping he had some amazing retort they could come back with.

“What do you losers want?” Bucky said in a voice that probably sounded much cooler in his head. The three stopped laughing and James smirked.

“Well I was just on my way over here to buy a soda and a bag of chips but it looks like you guys got me covered,” he said as he placed his open palm out. After seeing that the two were reluctant to hand over their snacks, James moved aside to let a big kid with an ill-fitting gold chain strapped around his fat neck step forward.

“If you guys aren’t gonna hand it over, then I guess I’ll just have to take it from you,” Blue said in a gruff voice. Timmy stepped back, ready to run, but Bucky stood his ground. Bucky sighed and looked at his feet as he held out the can of soda he had been hiding behind his back. Blue snorted with laughter and yanked the can from Bucky’s hand. He pulled the tab and cracked the can open. The soda burst out of the can and soaked his face in the sugary liquid. Bucky grabbed Timmy by the arm and the two ran as the teens gave chase.

Timmy’s feet stomped across the sidewalk peppered with dry leaves. He shot his head back to see his pursuers right on his tail. The cool wind whipped past his exposed skin as adrenaline pumped through his veins. He felt as if each step he took sent him flying forward, and each breath he took fueled him with a cool and crisp energy. He looked back once again to see Blue slowing down as his large chest heaved up and down. Timmy looked forward once more to see Bucky running left into a leaf ridden yard. He followed his friend into the yard and past its house. The backyard was blocked off by a large wooden fence. There was a small hole in the bottom of the fence that Bucky quickly crawled under. Hearing the sounds of crunching leaves, Timmy quickly followed suit, crawling under the fence and emerging on the other side. The pair slowed down and looked back at the fence. Timmy could see James’s face peek out of the hole in the fence, but he was too big to get through. Timmy looked over at Bucky who gave a soft chuckle, both of them too out of breath to do anything else.

Suddenly, a figure jumped over the tall wooden fence and rushed at the two. It was the tall and lanky figure of Jimmy. Timmy and Bucky ran away from the terrifying shape sprinting towards them. Timmy was practically panting at this point, beads of cold sweat dripping down his already cool forehead. They ran through the yard they had entered and out into the empty street. Once they reached the sidewalk, the two split up and ran in opposite directions. Timmy looked back once more and felt his heart drop as Jimmy chose to follow him. Timmy continued past the houses decorated with various spooky trinkets until he saw a brown porch adorned with a multitude of unlit jack-o-lanterns. He turned into the yard and ran up the porch steps, opening the door, shutting it behind him, and locking it. He looked out the door’s window to see Jimmy

slow to a halt in his yard. Jimmy looked to the door with malice in his eyes before spitting on the ground below him and sulking away. Timmy turned his back to the door and let out a sigh of relief.

The yellow light of the chandelier above flooded the dining room as Timmy took another bite of his pork.

“So Tim,” his father began to ask through a mouthful of mashed sweet potatoes before noticing his wife staring daggers at him. He quickly swallowed his food before continuing. “How was school today?”

“It was good,” Timmy said, clearly preoccupied with something. His parents noticed.

“Is there something wrong honey?” his mother asked. Timmy looked up a little embarrassed.

“No, I’m fine,” he paused, considering whether to tell his parents or not. “I was just thinking about this carnival that’s opening this Thursday,” he said in the most innocent voice he could muster. His parents exchanged worried glances.

“That Crimson show?” his father asked, clearly hoping his assumption was wrong.

“Yea, have you heard of it?” Timmy said, doing a very poor job to hide his excitement.

“I don’t think you should go to that,” his father said slowly.

“Why not? I know it’s a school night but I’ll wake up on time, I swear,” Timmy pleaded.

“Timmy,” his mother began in a friendly yet commanding voice, “I trust you, but that show is not meant for children. It doesn’t matter how much you ask, we’re not going to let you go.”

Timmy considered arguing but respected his parent’s decision enough to stay silent. He looked down at his plate and continued eating in silence. Once he finished dinner, he wished his parents a good night, as they did him, and walked up to his bedroom.

The sound of a buzzing phone ripped Timmy from his restful slumber into the pale light of his dark room, illuminated solely by his phone. He drowsily reached over and picked it up, wiping the sleep from his eyes. He squinted at the pale screen, blinding in the darkness of the room, to see a text from Bucky.

‘The show’s starting soon, you better hurry up!’ Timmy looked at the message confused and put his phone back down, hoping to go to sleep. He sighed and turned over in bed, gazing out his window. He noticed something in the distance which made him jump out of bed.

He saw bright red lights reaching out into the sky surrounding a giant circus tent, made tiny by its distance. Outside of the tent, Timmy could see a line of people all walking towards it like moths to a flame. Timmy ran back to his phone and turned it on, displaying the date: Thursday October 30st, 11:47pm. Timmy grew momentarily excited, but that excitement quickly shifted to disappointment. His parents would never let him go, even if every other kid in town was going; Not unless he snuck out.

He pushed open his bedroom door and looked out into the pitch black hallway. He took his first step, moving his hand along the wall towards where he presumed the stairs were. He took another step, wincing as the floorboards creaked underneath him. He heard a noise coming from his parent's room, as if someone had just gotten out of bed, and began to panic. He quickened his pace towards the stairs as the sound of footsteps appeared from behind the door. Timmy took another quick step but felt his foot only touch air. He grabbed at the walls around him, but as he got ahold of the railing leading down the stairs, he felt something bump into his back and send him spiraling down the staircase. He landed flat on his back, pain shooting throughout his body like blood pumping through his veins. He tried to move his arm but it felt like it was stuck to the ground beneath him.

The lights turned on and he looked over to his right arm. It was broken at the elbow, a small piece of bone tearing through his skin splattered with red. He felt hot tears trickling down his cheeks as he tried to scream, only managing out a whimper. He tilted his head up the stairs where he could see his parents. They stood next to each other, his mother's hand still on the lightswitch. His lip trembled as he was unable to ask for their help. They simply stood there at the top of the blood splattered staircase, grinning down at their mangled son.

Timmy gasped and shot out of bed. He grabbed his right arm, still too afraid to look at it, only to find it was perfectly intact. He let out a sigh of relief and fell back in his bed. He turned to face his window, only to see the grassy, tree-filled fields beyond his backyard. He turned again to grab his phone and turn it on. His phone read: Tuesday October 28th, 12:07am.

The sound of scraping chalk shook Timmy out of his half sleep. He couldn't get a wink of sleep last night after his nightmare, and even the cool breeze coming through the classroom's open windows was not enough to keep him alert. He looked up to the chalkboard to see the name 'Mrs. Evans'. An unfamiliar woman sat down at the teacher's desk and opened a book.

"I passed out a sign-in sheet, so just fill that out and continue working on whatever homework you have," the woman said while looking down at the book in her hands. Timmy smiled and put his head down again, thankful for whatever kept his teacher from coming in that day. He felt a poke on his back and looked over to see Bucky sitting in the desk behind him, and looking just as tired as he felt. Bucky handed him the sign-in sheet and he sloppily wrote his name before passing it on.

"What happened to you? It looks like you were up all night," Bucky asked with a light chuckle.

"I could ask you the same question," Timmy shot back before putting his head down on his desk. Bucky smiled before yawning and repeating this motion.

The bell rang for the eighth time that day as Timmy and Bucky ran out of school with the rest of the crowd. They drowsily made their way back towards the convenience store they always went to after school, both of them still very tired despite the extra sleep they got during the day.

They continued down the cracked sidewalk, yellow and orange leaves crunching underneath their shoes as the warm glow of the sun through the trees above offset the cool fall air.

“What do you think you’ll get at the store, another soda?” Bucky asked as he stretched his arms above his head. Timmy thought about it for a moment.

“Probably. I really just want something to wake me up,” Timmy admitted.

“Why are you so tired anyways?” Bucky asked once again. It was clear why he was asking, he was doing a very poor job at disguising his question as pure curiosity, but Timmy was wondering the same thing as his friend.

“Did you also have a weird dream last night?” Timmy asked Bucky, almost sure of the answer. Bucky looked down at his feet, his silence answering Timmy’s question.

“So are you still gonna go as a pirate?” Timmy asked, trying to change the subject. Bucky grinned momentarily, happy to have something to complain about.

“Ok, so yesterday after I got home I decided to try on my costume just to see if I still liked it. But when I went looking for it, all I could find was a stupid eyepatch. So for some reason I can not begin to comprehend, last spring, my genius dad decided to throw the costume away because he figured I’d never wear it again,” Bucky ranted. Timmy laughed and Bucky continued. “So now since my parents don’t have the time to drive me anywhere good, and I don’t want to go as a sheet ghost, my current choices are to go with one of those crumby masks sold at the dollar store, or to go as myself with an eyepatch,” Bucky finally finished as Timmy continued to chuckle. Bucky grinned, glad that he could lighten the mood for them both, and glad that he could complain to someone about his costume situation.

The two continued down the street until they reached the convenience store parking lot. The lot was mainly empty, and there were a few kids hanging out around the store. As the pair walked closer to the store they noticed a few posters taped to the store’s windows, all of them displaying the same image: a tall figure in a long flowing black cloak, wearing an expressionless white mask with two pitch black eye holes and two short curved horns.

‘Come see The Crimson Troupe! Opening Halloween morning at 12:00am,’ the poster read. The two tried to ignore the posters as they entered the store.

Despite its spooky exterior, the inside of the store looked like it typically did, save for an excess amount of candy and Halloween themed snacks. Timmy moved to the back of the store where they kept the drinks to grab a bottle of chilled coffee, he did not expect to enjoy it but he figured it was worth it for the caffeine. Bucky grabbed a candy bar and a can of soda and the two friends walked to the only cashier that ever seemed to be there, Phil.

“You two ready for Halloween?” Phil asked as he scanned Bucky’s candy bar. The pair nodded and Phil smiled. “Well I’ll tell you two what, I don’t got kids of my own, so come Halloween I’ll be waiting just down the street with a big bowl of candy,” Phil continued as he scanned Timmy’s bottle of coffee.

The two left the store and sat down on the sidewalk. Timmy opened his bottle of coffee and took a sip before wincing at the taste, it tasted just as bitter as he expected.

“We should probably avoid Phil’s house when we go trick-or-treating,” Bucky said after taking a swig of his soda. “That guy gives me the creeps.” Timmy took another sip of his coffee before closing the bottle and setting it beside him, deciding the caffeine was not worth it after all. He slouched against the store wall and looked up towards the sky. Just above him was one of the posters for The Crimson Troupe.

“Are you really going to try to sneak out to see that carnival?” Timmy asked blankly. Bucky took another drink before answering his question, possibly just to buy himself some time to think.

“Maybe,” he finally said, putting down the can to tear open his candy bar’s wrapper. The two sat there in silence for a moment. Timmy took out his phone to look at the time. ‘3:38’, James and his friends usually showed up at 3:30 to haggle the two. “I really want to go,” Bucky continued as he looked beyond the rows of orange leafed trees.

“So do I,” Timmy said.

Timmy sat bent over his desk, doing the homework he should have done yesterday. The orange light of the sky flooded in through his window as the sun prepared to disappear behind the trees and bring about the darkness of night. There was a light knock on Timmy’s door before it was opened by his smiling father. Timmy forced a similar smile and looked over warmly to his father.

“Hey bud, how’s it going?” his father asked in a cheery voice. Timmy held his facade well.

“I’m doing well, Mr. Miller wasn’t at school today so that was pretty cool,” Timmy replied.

“Good, good,” his father said as he jokingly nodded and smiled. Timmy looked back at his paper, working up the courage to ask his dad once again.

“Are you sure I can’t go to that carnival? I’m old enough for it, I swear,” Timmy pleaded with his father. His father’s kind smile dropped into a disapproving frown.

“Timmy,” his father started, clearly not wanting to have this conversation, “It doesn’t matter what you say, your mother and I aren’t going to let you go to that carnival.”

“Why not? What’s so bad about that show that’s keeping you from even mentioning it to me,” Timmy asked, more angry than anything else by now. His father looked down at his feet and sighed.

“You’ll learn when you’re older ok?” his father finally said before closing the door, prematurely ending the conversation. Timmy stood up to follow his father outside, but decided it was not worth the trouble. His parents were not going to tell him why he could not go to that show, even if he pleaded. Timmy sat back down in his chair and shifted his gaze back to the pages of homework he still needed to complete. A cool breeze blew through his open window as the orange glow of the setting sun darkened to a red hue. Even the usual joy brought about by Halloween was now eclipsed by his disappointment.

The cool air of fall, now heightened by the blackness of the night it came from, flooded through Timmy's room. Timmy shivered and pulled the blankets up to his neck, wishing he had remembered to close his window before he went to sleep. He decided that closing it now was better than never closing it at all and sat up in bed. He could hear music in the distance, very faint music, an accordion played slowly. Timmy opened his eyes and looked towards his window, seeing red lights in the distance surrounding a huge tent. Timmy rubbed his eyes to make sure he was not seeing things but his sight was true. The sound of plastic clattering on wood broke the calm of the distant music, and Timmy looked over to his phone. His phone screen displayed the time '11:47', along with a message from Bucky.

'The show's starting soon, you better hurry up!' Timmy quickly read the message, then looked back at the tent in the distance.

His bedroom door creaked open and he lightly placed one foot onto the cold wood floor of the hallway. He raised his phone's flashlight to illuminate the hallway as he stepped into it. He looked to his left to see the stairs leading to his escape, and planned out his path carefully. He took one long step as to avoid the creaky wood plank below him, and looked to his parent's room as if expecting them to burst out at any moment. He took another step, one step closer to his exit, but felt his heart begin to pound as he looked down at the floor beneath him. There was no way for him to know where to step next, but he was just wasting time standing there and doing nothing. He held his breath and took a step forward, the floorboards beneath him letting out a loud creak. He froze in place, his heart threatening to rip out of his chest with its unwieldy pounding. He heard the sound of shifting weight coming from his parents room and he sprinted down the stairs, holding out his phone to reveal his path to safety. He hopped down the last few steps, no longer caring about whatever noise he made, and ran towards the door in front of him.

The lights switched on and he froze in place, as if he had just awoke from a dream. He looked over to his left to see his father sitting in a big, cushiony chair. His father let his hand fall from the lamp he had just turned on and raised his head to look Timmy in the eyes.

"Dad, I-" Timmy started before his father cut him off.

"What the fuck were you thinking?" his father asked in a cold and disconnected voice. Timmy stood motionless, his father's words cutting through him like an icy dagger. He opened his mouth to speak but his lips refused to move. "When I said you couldn't go to that show, did you think I was fucking joking? Did you think I would just sit here and let your ungrateful ass walk right out that fucking door?" his father continued in the same monotone voice. Timmy looked down at his feet and held his hands together to keep them from shaking; Timmy could feel a frigid tear cling to his cheek before falling to the floor.

"I... I..." Timmy tried to stutter out, still staring at the floor.

"You what?" His father yelled out, making Timmy raise his hands above his head as if to protect himself from his father's words.

“I just... wanted to go...” Timmy managed to sputter out before breaking out into tears. His father stood out of the chair and walked up to Timmy, looking down at his shivering son. He grabbed Timmy’s chin, raising his head so Timmy could look into his eyes. “Dad,” Timmy stammered out through his tears, unable to get out anything else through his sniffles and tears.

“Quit crying you fucking pussy!” His father yelled at him before throwing him backwards onto the floor. Timmy tried to get up but his quivering arms could not support his weight. His father stepped towards him and raised his fist, bringing it down upon Timmy. He pulled his fist back once more and punched Timmy in the mouth. Timmy’s head fell back and he could taste blood. Timmy tried to push his father away but he raised his clenched and bruised fist once more.

The school bell rang loudly, startling Timmy as he sat at his desk, his head in his hands. He looked up to see the same unfamiliar woman writing the name ‘Mrs. Evans’ on the board. Timmy felt horribly groggy and tired, but he refused to go to sleep again. He glanced behind him to see that Bucky was still asleep. Timmy had nothing to distract himself with to keep him from falling asleep. He sighed and looked around at the classmates he had never bothered to know more about. They all looked just as tired as he did. His mind shifted back to the strange substitute. Mr. Miller was rarely out, and he did not have any kids of his own, so he must be pretty sick to be out two days in a row. The thought ended there and Timmy was back to trying not to fall asleep.

The sky above beamed through the trees, much more orange than days previous. Timmy and Bucky walked down the cracked sidewalk towards their usual destination of the convenience store. The wind momentarily picked up, whipping up a torn poster which had laid face down in the street. The poster flew over to the pair and landed at Timmy’s feet. He picked it up to find it was a large piece of the poster advertising the Crimson Troupe the two had seen yesterday, however, what he could see of the image was a bit different; The cloak the figure wore seemed tinted red, and the horns seemed longer than Timmy had remembered. He decided to pocket the torn poster, hoping to compare it with the ones from yesterday. Timmy felt especially groggy, and despite his extra minutes of sleep, Bucky was not any better, his slow movement showed it.

“When I get home, I’m just gonna go to bed and get some sleep,” Bucky said mainly to himself. Timmy just nodded. As they approached the destination they could hear the faint sound of music coming from within the store. Bucky was the first to notice it. “If the store’s gonna bother to play music that loud you would think they’d play something a bit more festive,” Bucky complained absentmindedly as they entered the parking lot. Timmy stood still for a moment as he recognized the music the store was playing. “I mean, what about accordions says Halloween?” Bucky continued. Timmy quickly got a hold of himself and continued walking, hoping Bucky did not notice his sudden unease.

Timmy felt a hand grab his shoulders and heard someone scream in his ear. He yelled and fell forwards onto the pavement next to Bucky who had received the same treatment. He turned to look behind him and saw the same featureless, horned face plastered on the poster in his pocket. The figure wearing the mask laughed maniacally before pushing up the mask to reveal the face of James. Jimmy and Blue ran out from behind a parked car to join the now hysterical James.

“How I wish you two could see your faces right now,” James said through his fit of laughter. Blue stepped in front of Bucky with a grimace on his face and pulled his fist back, thrusting it forward and stopping just before it hit him. Bucky raised his arms and closed his eyes in preparation of the fake-out, much to the delight of the trio. The fall had caused the poster in Timmy’s pocket to drop out onto the pavement, where it entered Jimmy’s line of sight. Before Timmy even realised he had lost the poster, Jimmy snatched it from the ground and unfolded it.

“Yo James, take a look’t this,” Jimmy said as his mouth upturned into a strange grin, “Looks like the babies wanna go to the grown up show.” Jimmy finished off his insightful retort with a wheezy laugh before handing the poster over to James. As James took the poster from Jimmy’s hands his face lit up for a moment before quickly dropping.

“Did you rip up this poster?” James said, squatting down to get closer to the two who still did not want to get up. Timmy and Bucky remained silent, unsure of what to say. Jimmy tapped James on the shoulder.

“Hey, I think yer missin’ the point,” Jimmy said, a little confused. James brushed Jimmy’s hand off his shoulder without responding. His breath grew rapid and he repeated his question with more force this time. The two still remained silent and James slowly reached into his back pocket, pulling out a switchblade, its hilt silver and its blade crimson. Bucky scuttled backwards but James grabbed Timmy’s collar before he had the chance to move and held the knife close to his throat. James’s face had turned dark, a twisted scowl making up his mouth and his eyes full of rage. Timmy looked up to Blue and Jimmy who seemed worried about this sudden change.

“No I didn’t rip the poster, we just found it like that,” Timmy yelled out fearfully. James continued to stare him down, each breath he took heavy and shaky.

“James, you okay?” Blue said in a quiet and scared voice Timmy had never heard before. James looked back up to Blue with the same hideous expression before bursting out laughing. He shoved Timmy backwards and stood up, pocketing the blade. Blue and Jimmy exchanged worried glances as James turned to leave the lot. He looked at his friends and let out a soft laugh.

“What’s wrong? I was just jokin’ around,” he said with a smile. Blue and Jimmy reluctantly followed James as he walked away from the parking lot. He turned his head back to Timmy and Bucky, pushing the mask back down over his face and tilting his head before leaving their sight.

Timmy and Bucky weakly stood up, dusting themselves off. Bucky looked over to Timmy who lightly trembled in place.

“Do you want to just go home?” Bucky asked quietly. Timmy shook his head as his house was the last place we wished to be. Bucky nodded and gave a weak smile. “Come on, let’s just get some snacks,” Bucky said as he put his arm around Timmy’s shoulder. Timmy returned the smile and the two walked over to the store. As they walked towards the store, they realized that the store’s windows were almost completely covered with the same poster, the one no longer in Timmy’s pocket.

They entered the musky store, most of the lights on the inside dimmed by fake black spiderwebs, and most of the light from outside was now blocked by the posters. The store was dark and felt much more claustrophobic than ever before with the extra halloween decorations, the sudden change in scenery made Timmy more baffled than anything else. He walked into the back of the store to grab a can of soda (the coffee had proved disappointing yesterday, plus he no longer felt very tired), as Bucky stayed by the front of the store to examine its selection of sweets. As Timmy turned to walk back to the cash register he noticed that the wall adjacent to him was filled with a white, expressionless, horned mask.

Despite the encounter mere minutes ago, he felt compelled to walk towards the masks. Giving into his compulsion, he stepped forward and grabbed one of the masks, carefully as if fearing it might break the second he laid a finger on it. He lifted it off its hook and held it in front of him to get a good look. The material felt like plastic, yet it looked of fine porcelain and on the mask’s back was a small elastic strap. Timmy slowly slipped the mask on and looked into a small mirror on the wall. The mask fit perfectly, as if it were made for Timmy, as did the look. Timmy stood still, savoring each second he spent staring into the mirror.

The sound of approaching footsteps broke Timmy from his trance and he ripped off the mask, hanging it back on the wall and turning the face the coolers which held every drink the store sold. Bucky came out from behind one of the aisles to grab a drink, not noticing Timmy’s broken enthrallment.

The pair put down their items at the cash register, behind which sat a strange woman. Her face was covered by a porcelain mask with small red lips and her clothing was rather extravagant, a long flowing red dress with long gloves. She took each of the boys’ items and scanned them slowly, seemingly having a little trouble. She realized the two had noticed the trouble she was having and gave an embarrassed giggle.

“Sorry about this, I’ve never had to stand in for Phil before” she said, placing the items in a plastic bag.

“That’s fine,” Timmy reassured her before Bucky could get out the complaint he was sure Bucky was going to say.

The two left the store, snacks in hand, and sat where they always did to eat. Timmy took a sip of his soda and opened his bag of chips before speaking his mind.

“Does it worry you that Paul isn’t here today?” Bucky finished a long gulp of his drink before shaking his head no. The two remained mainly silent for the rest of their time at the store.

The orange glow of the soon to be setting sun shone brightly through the stained window. Timmy sat on his couch watching television. As the cartoon he had been so invested in cut to commercials, he shifted his focus to the orange sunlight in which danced small particles of dust. He heard the door creak open as his mother walked into their house.

“Hey Tim, how was school?” she asked sweetly. Timmy shifted his focus once again, this time to his mother.

“It was good,” Timmy responded mechanically. As his mother moved to put her bag down on the kitchen table, the tv faded to black, catching Timmy’s attention. The all too familiar melody began to play overtop the black nothingness on screen. As his mother re-entered the room, an image came into view on the tv screen, the image of a horned mask; Its horns were fairly long and curved upwards, like an elephant’s tusks, and the eyeholes were a pale red. The image faded out, replaced by text reading ‘It all begins tomorrow’. Timmy expectantly looked back to his mother, not surprised by the look of disapproval painted on her face.

“Why can’t I go?” Timmy asked his mother, accompanying the question with a disappointed stare. His mother sighed, clearly frustrated by the repeated question.

“Timmy, that show is just not for kids,” his mother said almost pleadingly.

“How do you know? I’ve seen posters all around town advertising the troupe and none of them said anything about it not being ok for kids. Plus I just turned ten, isn’t that old enough?” The last remark almost made his mother smile, had it not been for the subject matter they were discussing. She walked back into the kitchen and Timmy could hear her pull out the garbage can. She began to rummage through the cluttered trash, mumbling to herself:

“You think they would have the decency not to put up posters about that show,” before finally walking back into the room holding a crumpled piece of paper. She pulled out a pen from her pocket and began to furiously scribble out several words on the page. After finishing, she walked over to Timmy and showed him the censored page. Of what he could make out, the poster read: ‘The Crimson Troupe is coming to your town! You have all been lucky enough to be visited by Crimson herself, the ----- . So get ready for ----- and the like, for this event is one you will never forget!’ In the middle of the poster was an image that Timmy could not make out, hidden by his mother’s scribbles.

“This poster showed up at our doorstep a few days ago, and I am just thankful you weren’t the one to find it,” she finished her statement by ripping the poster in half and pocketing the ruined paper. “So that’s how I know the show is not for kids, it is sultry trash masquerading as something more important with all those posters around town.” She left the room in a huff, not allowing Timmy to say anything more. He turned back towards the tv, the horned mask returned his stare.

The room was dark, the night quiet. Timmy was unsure of what awoke him, he only knew that he was up now. He shifted his body and laid on his side, facing his window. His eyes shot

open when he saw a familiar red light outside in the distance, and his excitement grew. He looked over to his phone just as it began to buzz, the screen lighting up to display a text from Bucky reading, ‘The show’s starting soon, you better hurry up!’ Timmy quietly got out of bed, at least as quietly as one could with such anticipation, and made his way towards the window. He pushed it open, letting in a gust of cool wind, and looked longingly to the red tent in the distance. Timmy knew he could not leave through the front door, nor did he want to anymore, so his gaze shifted downward towards the bushes at the foot of his house. His room was on the second floor, but the bushes looked fairly soft, he just needed to get to that show. He needed to see The Crimson Troupe.

After a few deep breaths, he slowly put one leg through the window and grabbed onto the inside of the window sill. Putting his other leg through, he painfully hung onto the sill for a moment before dropping into the bushes below.

As he hit the ground, he heard a crunch over the sound of the crushed bushes. He would have screamed in pain were it not for the breath being knocked out of his chest. He sputtered, attempting to gain back his lost breath, before slowly and painfully turning over onto his stomach. With great strength, he pushed himself onto his knees, and from there he stood hunched over in pain. He could feel something out of place in his back, keeping him from standing straight, yet he remained reserved. With tears of pain rolling down his red cheeks, he began to walk forward into the forest in his backyard. The terrain was much rougher, but time was of the essence, and it was the most direct path to the tent. The light of street lamps ceased their illuminance as Timmy continued into the dark woods, yet the slow accordion continued strong. Timmy continued rather quickly through the woods before the adrenaline began to fade. The pain in his back became more pronounced, and his feet dragged with every step he took. As his vision began to fade, the sound of whirring tires broke through the quiet forest. Timmy looked back in concern to see headlights. He continued forward with greater urgency than before, the headlights quick on his tail. A sharp pain shot throughout his body as he took a wrong step, and he dropped onto the side of a tree. He turned back to see the headlights brighten as the car from which they came approached. Timmy pushed himself from the tree before the car reached him, and the vehicle smashed into the side of the tree having no time to react.

Timmy looked back to the car, its hood mangled and billowing smoke. He tried to move backwards but was unable to for the pain it caused him. The car door swung open, nearly falling off its hinges in the process, and a figure stepped out, shrouded in smoke. The figure walked forward, dragging a long and narrow object with them. Out of the smoke Timmy could see his mother, her face maimed and bloody. She was hunched over and dragging an axe across the ground in one hand, the other hand covering a gaping wound on her shoulder. Timmy tried to move once more but found it of no use.

“Mom...” Timmy began to plead, “I’m sorry mom, I’m sorry I swe-” He was cut off before he could finish his thought by his mother’s foot on his throat. His arms reached up to grasp at her leg in a futile attempt to push her off. “You’re... hurting... me” he finally managed

to get out before his mother grasped the axe with both hands and held it high above her head, a look of unbridled rage for her son.

“As long as I live, you will never see that show,” she spat at him before swinging the axe down into his head.

Calm wind blew some of the precariously placed leaves off their perches. Timmy rested his head on his fist, staring out into the gold sunlight of the early October morning. The same substitute sat at the front of the class, and behind him Bucky sat scratching at his desk. Timmy took a deep breath, feeling more calm than usual as he watched the orange and yellow leaves drift peacefully to the ground. Peaceful, that was what he felt, peaceful. This feeling of peacefulness scared Timmy, he was not himself and he knew why.

Timmy turned to Bucky, still squirming feverishly at his desk, and gave him a calm smile. Bucky seemed irritated by this, and gave Timmy a strangely angry yet terrified look.

“What’s wrong?” Timmy asked softly, still with a plainly content expression.

“I don’t wanna talk about it,” Bucky grumbled before continuing to scratch into the desk. By now the desk was significantly scratched and dented. Timmy turned back to face the window, figuring they could talk about it at the convenience store. He suspected what Bucky was considering, supposing some people simply have different reactions to a situation.

The bell dismissed the school at the end of the day, but most of the pupils who stepped into the cool fall air seemed gloomy, some anxious, only a few as giddy as one would expect.

Timmy and Bucky continued down the street, dry leaves crunching underneath their feet. A group of kids wearing costumes passed by them, perhaps they were just that excited for Halloween. Timmy smiled at the passersby, while Bucky continued to stare at the ground. After a minute of walking, Bucky looked up at Timmy.

“Why are you so damn calm?” Bucky asked in an almost envious voice. Timmy returned his anxious stare with one of tranquil satisfaction before responding in a smooth voice.

“Because I figured it out,” he simply replied. This took Bucky aback momentarily, not expecting the answer he expected.

“And you’re ok with that?” Bucky asked in a quiet voice, “You aren’t scared at all?” Timmy smiled before answering Bucky.

“It’s the only option,” he finally responded. Bucky looked around the block nervously, seeing a surplus of posters all advertising the same show beginning that very night. Bucky sighed and forced a bitter-sweet smile.

As they approached the convenience store, they could see the figure of James sitting in front of the automatic doors of the store, his feet resting in the pavement of the parking lot. He looked especially jittery, and in his hands he fidgeted with his switchblade. When Bucky noticed him he tugged at Timmy’s arm away from the store, but Timmy put his hand up in an effort to

reassure Bucky. Timmy walked forward to the lone James, who soon noticed his presence and held the knife firmly in one hand. James stood up, towering over Timmy.

“What do you want?” James growled in a frighteningly blatant tone. He was not mocking Timmy or trying to intimidate him with insults, his presence was enough of a threat to scare the bravest of souls away. Timmy was startled by this, but he knew running back would not accomplish anything.

“Where’s Blue and Jimmy?” Timmy asked, trying to sound as honest as he possibly could.

“Why do you want to know?” James said once more in that terrifying tone.

“I’m just curious that’s all,” Timmy said sincerely. James raised one eyebrow before dropping his head.

“We got into a fight,” James finally replied after much pause.

“I’m guessing they didn’t want to go to the show tonight,” Timmy responded. James’s head perked up, his interest peaked. He opened his mouth to talk, but bit his tongue and clenched his teeth.

“Those mother fuckers have lost their goddamn minds! They’re saying I’m obsessed for wanting to go to the show, but how can they not be constantly thinking about it. It’s infesting my mind and the only way I can satisfy my craving is to go, is that so fucking complicated? How can you not be constantly thinking about it, constantly talking about it, constantly wishing every moment that you could finally have the chance to experience something you have been dreaming about for days? Those fucking assholes brushed off their thoughts as ridiculous, and they say I’m the one with no sense, they fucking deserved to-” James cut off here, clutching his hand to his quivering mouth, tears streaming down his cheeks. Timmy just gave a weak smile and walked over to him, putting his arm on James’s shoulder for comfort. James caught Timmy off guard by embracing him in an admittedly uncomfortable hug.

When James let go of Timmy he was smiling a little and his tears were less numerous. James gave a sigh and began to walk away from the store.

“Ask Marisa about going to the show tonight,” James said as he left before stopping suddenly and turning to Timmy. “And... thanks.” With that James walked into the street and out of sight.

Bucky stared at Timmy in disbelief at the event which had just transpired. Timmy shrugged and smiled, he supposed the show had brought people together in some ways.

The pair stepped into the now familiar convenience store, dark cobwebs hanging from the ceiling, obscuring the light. Bucky hovered around the front of the store, examining the shelf of candy which had not been there the day previous. Timmy glanced to the shelf to find he did not seem to recognize any of the brands. He paid the shelf no mind however, for he only had one thing in mind. He traveled towards the back of the store where they kept the drinks, and turned to face the left wall. Where masks had been adorned a mere day ago, only one remained. Timmy

stepped towards the mask, touching the cool frame with the tips of his fingers. He pulled the mask off its hook and slowly pulled the strap back, sliding the mask over his face. He turned to look into the mirror on the wall, the expressionless horned face staring back at him. He stared into that mirror for minutes, though to him it only felt a few seconds.

He finally managed to rip his stare from the mirror and he slipped off the mask, walking back towards the register. As he turned the corner he could see Bucky was at the register talking to the cashier, the same masked woman from yesterday. It seemed like he was crying. She pushed his chin up softly and wiped away a tear with one gloved finger. He smiled and hugged her quickly before running out of the store. Timmy walked towards the cashier and put the mask down at the register. He glanced towards the door which Bucky left from, an action the cashier noticed.

“Are you worried about your friend?” she asked in a sweet voice. Timmy looked back at her, not expecting the question.

“Yea, he seems really shaken up,” Timmy said with a sigh. She tilted her head.

“And what about you?” This question especially took Timmy by surprise.

“What do you mean?” He asked back.

“Are you going to the Crimson Troupe’s show tonight?” the woman asked. Timmy nodded in response.

“Then how are you feeling?” she asked once again. Timmy looked to the ground.

“I... don’t know I guess. I’ve kind of tried not to think about it. I know what I have to do, and I’ve come to terms with the fact that I have to do it, but I haven’t really pictured myself doing it yet,” Timmy said, still looking at the ground. Even the fact that he could not say what ‘it’ is out loud showed his hesitation.

“Do you want to do it?” he heard her ask him. He did not respond. She scratched the back of her head and picked up the mask he planned on buying. “Because you don’t have to.” This made Timmy look up. She held up the mask to show him. Timmy smiled and she handed him back the mask. “Free of charge,” she said. Timmy could almost hear the blink in her tone of voice. She reached underneath the counter and rummaged around for something. Timmy smiled once again at her kindness and generosity. He felt himself again.

He stepped outside into the cool fall air and looked over to his right; Bucky was sitting where the pair always does, examining his bar of chocolate. Timmy sat down next to him. Bucky looked over to Timmy, noticing the mask in his hand.

“Nice mask,” Bucky said in earnest. Timmy smiled and nodded. Bucky tore open the wrapper which Timmy could now see read ‘Kudize’. Inside were two small pieces of chocolate, making Timmy’s face instinctively turn to one of a beggar. Bucky rolled his eyes and handed Timmy one of the pieces, giving a soft smile to show he was not too disappointed by his loss. As Timmy ate the piece of candy, he could sense it tasted somewhat strange and off-brand, almost like it had a somewhat spicy aftertaste. It was very sweet though so it did not matter much to

Timmy. After he finished the candy he felt much more comfortable. He looked up to the posters on the store's walls. The mask on the poster looked much different than days previous, its horns reaching high and curved like a hook, and its eye holes red.

The yellow light of the chandelier above flooded the room and Timmy took a large bite from his plate of turkey and greens. His parents talked to each other, possibly to him but he could not be sure. He quickly gobbled up the rest of his food and excused himself from the table, he wished not to hear their voices much longer.

"Wanna play a game or something? It's still pretty early," his father asked as Timmy approached the stairs his parents had pushed him down. He responded with 'no' and, not wanting to have to think of an excuse, bound up the stairs. He closed the bedroom door behind him and stepped over to his bed. He sat down and stared out the window towards the large tent showered in crimson twilight. He thought not of his parents, or making it to the tent, or his future, all he needed to do was enjoy the show.

The rattling of his buzzing phone woke Timmy from his restful sleep. He turned to his side and reached for his phone which illuminated the room. A message displayed across the screen, a message from Bucky.

'The show's starting soon, you better hurry up!'. Timmy rubbed the sleep out of his eyes and reread the message along with the time displayed, 11:47pm. He turned to look out his window. Outside, breaking through the harsh black of night, were red spotlights reaching into the sky, surrounding the huge tent. Timmy got out of bed and slinked over to his dresser, expressionless. He opened the bottom drawer and took out the pile of neatly folded clothes to reveal a white horned mask. He grabbed the mask and strapped it around his head, before reaching back into the drawer for something else. He pulled out a switchblade, the moonlight from outside illuminating its silver handle. He flicked out the blade and turned it over in his hand, watching the light flood over the knife's crimson blade.

The mask stepped out into the dark hallway, taking slow steps towards where he suspected his parent's room to be. He felt along the adjacent wall until he reached a door knob. He clicked the door open and stepped inside. The curtains were closed so barely any light seeped into the room, just enough to make out the shape of a bed with two figures lying peacefully asleep. The mask made his way to one side of the bed and stood over the sleeping figure. He raised the switchblade in his hand and plunged it down without hesitation.

The door opened into the crowded night and the mask stepped out barefoot onto the cold pavement of the street, a street which was flooded with hordes of kids and teenagers just like him. The mask followed the crowd as they collectively made their way to the tent. He looked around at the other kids, many of whom were wearing the same mask. A few were wearing costumes of their own, perhaps for the same purpose, or perhaps it was just what they wanted to

do. The crowd slowly made its way through the streets flooded with dark crimson light, towards the towering tent in the distance.

As the mask approached the tent the crowd thinned out into a neat line. He waited excitedly as with each minute he grew closer to the show. Eventually, he stepped to the front of the line and was met with the smiling mask of Marisa.

"I'm so glad you ended up coming!" she said in a cheering voice once she saw the mask. "Go right on in, it's free of charge," she said, her mask winking for her. Timmy took off his mask and smiled back at her before stepping into the tent.

The air was warm and a feeling of calm excitement washed over Timmy. He looked around the large tent, the walls crowded with shouting and cheering kids eagerly awaiting the show. Timmy scanned the audience for a minute, eventually landing on his eyepatched friend sitting high up in the balcony. Timmy ran up the stairs to his right and pushed through the aisles of filled seats until he reached Bucky. Upon seeing his friend Bucky shouted with excitement.

"Hey man! You came just in time," Bucky pointed down at the middle of the tent, in which sat a large stage. Timmy sat down next to Bucky, impressed by his improvised costume of a towel wrapped around his head and a brown jacket in addition to his eyepatch and blood stained knife. He was eating from a large bag of popcorn and offered some to Timmy, much to his pleasure. The entire tent fell silent as a short man walked out into the middle of the stage holding a microphone. He held the microphone to his mouth and spoke softly into it.

"Ladies and gentlemen it is my pleasure to introduce to you the great, the beautiful, the powerful, Lady Crimson!" The audience erupted into applause and shouting after this line. Timmy grabbed the railing of the balcony and leaned forward, yelling with excitement. The short man stepped off the stage as it began to shake. A small circle in the middle of the stage formed and opened up. Red smoke billowed out from within and the lights in the tent dimmed. A spotlight appeared in the middle of the room, illuminating the hole in the stage. From that hole, a figure began to rise. Her face was a mask of white, large antlers sprouting from her forehead and reaching high above. She was wearing a dark cloak of black, splotted with red, which hung down past her feet and covered the floor. As she emerged, the crowd went wild with screams of excitement. She looked up to the crowd, her eyes dim red lights. She stood tall and seemed to tower above any other man. From within her cloak she pulled out a long and thin arm, raising her hand to silence the crowd. They all did as she commanded, for she had absolute control over the crowd, they would do anything for her. She lowered her hand back into the shroud of her cloak and, though she did not have a mouth, she spoke in a beautiful voice, unmatched by any other heard by man.

"Now then, let us begin the show."